Holy Cow

By David Duchovny

ELSIE: *(Chpt 1)* Hello, allow me to introduce myself. I'm a cow and my name is Elsie. See ? *(holds up hooves)* All animals can speak to one another: lion to lamb, bird to dog, moose to cat – except, really, who would ever want to have a lengthy conversation with a cat? *(laugh that turns into a MOO)* But I digress. Digression and digestion. It's what we do. We stand, we eat, we talk . . . It's all good. At least it ***was*** all good. Till about two years ago. That's when The Event happened. That's what I call it -- the Event, or the Revelation, or the Day the Patty Hit the Fan. *(Chpt 3)* See, the time came and I seized it. The eldest was milking me. He's got the thumb of one hand on his phone the whole time. I have come to learn this is called "texting," -- a way for people to tell one another stupid things about their day. Oh look, here's a picture of my lunch with an oh-so-witty caption. Oh look, here's a picture of me making a silly face, and another picture of a different face. Selfies, they call 'em. *(snort)* There's much about people I do not understand. Anyway, he starts muttering under his breath, grabs the pail of my milk, and stomps out of the barn. And guess what? He forgets to shut the gate. *(sneaks out of the gate)*

INTRODUCTION

And so begins the adventure of a lifetime for Elsie, a unassuming cow on a small farm in upstate New York, who believes India is the only place to be. She teams up with Jerry, a Torah-reading pig who plans to use kosher dietary laws to his advantage in Jerusalem and Tom, a anorexic Turkey who needs an escape before November. Together these common animals point a way toward an understanding and acceptance that the world so desperately needs.

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ELSIE: *(Chpt 8)* I don't know what made me head toward the house. It was destiny. I crept to an open window. The whole family was there quietly staring at a lighted box; hushed like the light box was their god and this Box God was talking.

REPORTER: *(Chpt 9)* The small farm is dead, replaced by huge industrial meat farms the size

of a small town. Here, at this plant . . . *(gestures to roll video)*

ELSIE: *(in horror)* Cows were being kept in this huge building, separated from one another by these metal chutes. A man held a metal rod up to the cow's head, and she collapsed! *(Moo that turns into the word)* Murdered. One after another! *(observing with curiosity) (Chpt 17)* The passive and drooling humans broke out of their stupor long enough to fight over "channels." I realized that the Box God is not just one god, but many, and with a magic plastic wand, humans can switch from god to god. The Discovery God mentions the name of this one place: India!

REPORTER 2: *(with Indian accent)* In India, cows are "sacred," which means respected and special. In India, cows are considered gods and no one eats them.

ELSIE: *(Chpt 18)* India . . . India . . . I became fixated on the house and more secrets I might learn. I [waited until] the family was going to be away for a while, and then I would go down to the house and continue my research. I found children's books where cows were heroic. A cow even jumped over the moon in one! Admittedly, it got unbelievable by the end and totally lost me when the dish ran away with the spoon (I mean, come on), but still, that was one bad cow. I found other books with maps that showed me where this magical land of India was. How lucky those cows were that were born in India and got to spend their lives there. And then I thought: Why not me? ***WHY CAN'T I GO TO INDIA?***

(Chpt 19) (long low moo) I was now a cow on a mission – Operation India. I knew it was on the other side of the world and that I would have to cross an ocean. (Ever seen a cow swim? Exactly.) *(Chpt 20)* [But] I had no idea how I was going to get on a plane. *(chewing cud and thinking, she is interrupted by Jerry, the Pig)*

JERRY: *(oinking snort)* 'Sup? I'll tell you what I think is up. I think you're planning to get outta Dodge, makin' a break, skedaddling, blowing this Popsicle stand . . .

ELSIE: So what if I am?

JERRY: I wanna go too. You think you're the only one who knows the lay of the land? They're gonna eat me just like they're gonna eat you. And I got mad skills. I can help.

ELSIE: Look, Jerry, even if I could take you, the same thing is going to happen to you in

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India. Cows are sacred in India, but pigs are just, well, pigs.

JERRY: Not India . . . Israel, baby. They hate us pigs so much they won't eat us! It'll be heaven. I'll walk down the street, and people will get outta my way like I'm Clint Eastwood. Nobody will talk to me, they won't even look at me, but best of all, I won't wind up on their plates next to some friggin' apple sauce!

ELSIE: *(contemplating, to audience)* I'd be a god and he'd be a devil, and we both would live. Humans are ridiculous, but we were desperate. So I relented. *(Chapter 21)* Jerry was a pain in the tuchus, but he was pretty helpful with logistics. *(Elsie is interrupted by Tom, the Turkey)*

TURKEY: Are you Elsie Bovary?

ELSIE: Who wants to know?

TURKEY: *(in 007 fashion)* Turkey, Tom Turkey.

ELSIE: Turkeys have always struck me as really nervous, but ***this*** turkey was also rail-thin and his feathers were flying off in every direction. When was the last time Tom had a meal? *(to Tom)* I've got some slop here the pigs left and some chicken feed the chickens didn't finish.

TOM: Are you insane? Keep that food away from me! November is just a few months away!

ELSIE: And what happens in November, you fly south and wanna look good in your mankini? Oh wait, you can't fly . . .

TOM: Do I have to spell it out for you? *(agitated turkey clucking)* Thanksgiving!!! Millions of people in America will eat a turkey!!! *(looks around furtively, then speaks in a whisper)* I gotta get to Turkey!! That's my country, those are my peeps. Do you think for a moment that they are going to eat the thing their country is named after?

ELSIE: You have a point . . . but I'm already traveling with a pig I gotta get to Israel. And you're a bird that can't fly. You're an oxymoron.

TOM: *(offended)* Calling me a moron! Hurtful, just hurtful. *(pause)* But what if I added value to the enterprise? *(takes a cell phone from under his wing)*

ELSIE: *(to audience)* A cellular phone, exactly the thing I'd been coveting for the journey. *(to Tom)* Impressive, But it's of no use to me. I can't work it with these hooves and neither

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can Jerry.

TOM: Check it. *(begins pecking at the phone)*

ELSIE: *(to audience)* He had the weather, Uber, even Siri was at his whim! *(trying to cover her glee)* You're in! *(Chpt 26)* The plan was to try to reserve airline tickets to India, Israel, and Turkey and then head on out to the airport in disguise. I had memorized the farmer's credit card numbers—Visa and Amex—so I was pretty sure we could charge the tickets. The rest would be easy.

(Chpt 27) We popped into a clothing store to buy raincoats, glasses and hats as disguises. Then a bookstore, and lifted some books on Judaism for Jerry, a Star of David for him to wear around his neck and a yarmulke for his head. *(Chpt 28)* No one seemed to know who, or rather what, we were. *(Chpt 31)* I'm sure we made for an interesting sight—big ol' me, well over six feet on my hind legs in a beige raincoat and sunglasses, and Jerry dressed in the velvet pants of a schoolboy, holding our pet turkey by the leash. We had had the foresight to register Tom as a comfort turkey.

********Scene – On the plane *******

ELSIE: *(Chpt 34) (awkwardly trying to make it down the narrow aisle of the plane; she finally sits)* Not much leg room! *(to audience)* None of the flight attendants gave us any trouble, 'cause everyone acts like an animal on a plane. We didn't stick out at all. Actually, I think we were the most human-acting folk on this flight. The people were disgusting. You should've seen the bathroom. *(flight takes off)*

WOMAN: *(Chpt 35)(complaining about the service)* They treat us just like cattle up here, just like cows.

ELSIE: Moooooooo!

WOMAN: *(laughing)* That's right, like damn cows, moooo!

JERRY: *(extremely nervous)* You've heard the expression "When pigs fly"? There's a reason for that – we're not supposed to be up here! Anybody got an Ambien? Oh, geez . . .

TOM: *(flaps his wings and manages to get to a window, he opens the shade and marvels at the sky)* There she is! Soooo beautiful! I'm a bird, mama. *(flapping wings gently)* I'm [flying]!

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PA ANNOUNCEMENT: Buckle up for our final descent [into Turkey]!

JERRY: *(squeals as the plane hits turbulence)* We're all gonna die! We're all gonna die!

ELSIE: *(Chpt 36)* [When] our wheels touched down [we were the last to leave the plane]. Tom hesitated at the cockpit, looking longingly at the controls like he didn't want to leave.

TOM: *(to the others)* During that flight, I realized my home is up there in the sky. I am a man with no country but the wild blue yonder.

ELSIE: And he bounded thorough the open door into the cockpit, strapped on a headset and started flicking buttons.

TOM: Birds fly. That's what they do!

ELSIE: And the "bird" slammed the cockpit door in our faces! The next we heard from Tom was over the PA system.

TOM: This is your captain speaking, looks like we are one or two on the runway here. So, put up your tray tables and adjust your seats to the upright position. We'll have you at Israel's Ben Gurion International Airport in no time! Flight attendants, prepare for takeoff.

ELSIE: There were no flight attendants.

JERRY: *(yelling)* You're a madman! I'm gonna punch you in the gizzard, you schlimazel!

ELSIE: *(Chpt 41)* [After landing] we walked by cafes. People gave us no smiles, got out of our way or muttered under their breath.

JERRY: *(confidently)* This is a bacon-free zone. It's heaven. Eat me? They don't even want to touch me! *(grabs a menu from one of the café tables, scans it, then triumphantly)* See that, no ham, no bacon, no me! Kosher heaven!

MAN: Swine! Devil!

ELISE: Apparently, pigs were associated with devils in ancient lore. Maybe the cloven hooves? Soon there was a growing crowd advancing toward us.

JERRY: *(Chpt 42)* RUNNNNNNNNN!

TOM: To the plane! Let's blow this clambake!

ELSIE: *(Chpt 43)* Luckily our plane was still on the tarmac and we were able to board without

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any further incident. Tom took off in seconds.

JERRY: I don't know if I could've made it there anyway. I like to be liked too much.

ELISE: And Jerry was once again a pig without a homeland.

TOM: *(Chpt 44) (on the PA system)* This is your captain speaking. [Soon] we will arrive at our final, I said final, destination: *(dramatic pause)* Mumbai, India!

ELSIE: Now it was my turn to look out the window *(opens shade)* My own promised land! Wheels touched tarmac and we began walking. *(looks around in confusion)* I started to second guess myself. Everywhere I looked, people seemed worse off than animals, and animals were being treated even worse than in the States. Had I been a fool?

We tried to cross a busy intersection. Cars, buses, and taxis careened by even more crazily than they do in the States. I told Shalom and Tom to jump on my back. (I was back to walking on all fours all the time again—I could be a cow!) I put one hesitant hoof onto the road and the oncoming traffic halted like I had just put the world on pause *(looks up in amazement)* Not one car honked. They waited for ME! A man in rags put his forehead on my forehead and stroked me, murmured lovingly, and then went on his way. It was true. It was all true. I was a queen! I could go wherever I pleased, and no one tried to touch Tom or Jerry while they were on my back.

JERRY: *(Chpt 45)* This is it! We hit the jackpot. We are gods!

ELSIE: *(Chpt 46)* I spotted a herd of Indian cows. My people! *(rushes to the herd)* Greetings and salutations! I'm Elsie. I've come from America.

MATRIARCH OF THE HERD: *(haughty, disdainful, cold)* Why do you keep company with pigs and birds?

ELSIE: They're my friends.

MATRIARCH OF THE HERD: Indian cows only have other Indian cows for friends. We are goddesses. We cannot associate with animals such as these. You threaten the whole hierarchy with your behavior.

ELSIE: *(modestly and matter of fact)* I'm not a goddess, I'm just an animal, we're all animals, just like pigs, birds, just like humans, for that matter.

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MATRIARCH OF THE HERD: If you show the humans we're animals, they will begin to treat us like animals, and eat us like animals, the way they do in your country. You're a goddess, act like one or be shunned by us other goddesses.

ELSIE: *(taking a firmer stance)* I'm not a goddess. *(Chpt 47)* It is not right to be reviled, nor is it right to be worshipped. We are not gods and goddesses, nor are we devils and beasts. We are all animals: pigs, birds, cows, humans. Perfect animals created in the infinite image and imagination of nature. We are all one! *(in amazement at her new understanding)* Moooooooo! . . . . Holy Cow!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Duchovny
ISBN: 978-0374172077
Publisher: Farrar, Straus and Giroux
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2015

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier
FL State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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